

Detailed Lesson Plan

Generational Communication Training for New Interns

Course Title: Communicating Up: Building Confidence Across Generations
Experience Theme: Communication Challenge Lab
Company: NorthStar Rail
Audience: New graduate interns
Duration: 90 minutes
Format: Interactive instructor-led workshop
Delivery Mode: In person or virtual
Training Purpose: Help new interns communicate clearly, professionally, and confidently with senior managers and leaders.

1. Lesson Overview

Course Goal

By the end of the training, new interns will be able to adapt their communication style when interacting with senior managers and leaders by using clear structure, professional tone, active listening, and feedback-response strategies in common workplace situations.

Learning Objectives

By the end of the session, learners will be able to:

#	Learning Objective
1	Identify common communication expectations between interns and senior leaders
2	Differentiate casual, professional, and leadership-facing communication styles
3	Apply the CLEAR framework to emails, chats, and verbal updates
4	Demonstrate how to ask specific questions and clarify expectations
5	Respond to feedback using a professional and growth-oriented approach
6	Create a personal 30-day communication action plan

2. Materials Needed

Material	Purpose
Slide deck	Main visual support
Participant worksheet	Reflection, practice, and action planning
CLEAR communication checklist	Job aid for workplace use
Scenario cards	Group and pair activities
Polling tool / sticky notes	Opening participation activity
Timer	Keep activities moving
Post-session survey	Evaluation

3. Lesson Plan at a Glance

Section	Tim	Main Focus	Activity
Opening: Communication Reality Check	10 min	Build relevance and safety	Poll + discussion
Module 1: Manager Lens	15 min	Understand senior manager expectations	Scenario analysis
Module 2: CLEAR Framework	20 min	Structure manager-ready communication	Message-building practice
Module 3: Message Makeover Challenge	20 min	Improve tone in email/chat	Team rewrite challenge
Module 4: Ask Better Questions	15 min	Speak up and clarify expectations	Pair role-play
Module 5: Feedback and Follow-up	5 min	Respond to feedback	Best-response activity
Closing: 30-Day Commitment	5 min	Transfer learning to work	Action plan

Total: **90 minutes**

4. Detailed Lesson Plan

Opening: Communication Reality Check

Item	Details
Time	10 minutes

Learning Objective	Prepare learners to recognize why communication with senior leaders matters
Purpose	Create relevance, normalize communication anxiety, and increase participation early
Materials	Slides, poll tool or sticky notes, participant worksheet

Facilitator Actions

1. Welcome learners to the session.
2. Introduce the session as a **Communication Challenge Lab**, not a lecture.
3. Explain that the goal is to practice realistic workplace communication situations.
4. Launch the opening poll.

Opening Poll Question

What feels hardest when communicating with senior managers or leaders?

Options:

- A. I do not know how formal I should be
- B. I worry my question sounds obvious
- C. I do not know how much detail to include
- D. I feel nervous speaking in meetings
- E. I am not sure how to respond to feedback

Learner Actions

Learners vote individually, then briefly discuss the results with the group.

Facilitator Debrief

Key message:

These challenges are normal for new professionals. The goal today is not to become someone else. The goal is to communicate with more clarity, confidence, and awareness of what managers need.

Assessment Check

Learners can name at least one communication challenge that is relevant to their internship experience.

Module 1: Manager Lens — What Senior Leaders Need

Item	Details
Time	15 minutes
Learning Objective	Identify common communication expectations between interns and senior leaders
Purpose	Help interns understand communication from the manager's perspective
Materials	Slides, worksheet, scenario card

Key Concept

Senior managers often need communication that is:

Manager Expectation	Meaning
Clear	The main point is easy to understand
Concise	Only necessary details are included
Timely	Issues or questions are raised early enough
Action-oriented	The message includes a request, decision, or next step
Professional	Tone is respectful and appropriate
Ownership-based	The intern shows preparation and responsibility

Activity: Manager Lens Scenario

Show learners this scenario:

You are assigned to support a safety reporting project. Your manager asks for a draft summary by Thursday. On Wednesday afternoon, you realize you are unsure which data source to use. You send this message:

“Hi, I’m confused about the data. Can you help?”

Learner Task

In small groups, learners answer:

1. What is unclear about this message?

2. What would the manager still need to know?
3. How could this message be improved?

Facilitator Actions

1. Give groups 4 minutes to discuss.
2. Ask 2–3 groups to share.
3. Capture common answers on the slide, board, or chat.
4. Connect responses to manager expectations.

Expected Learner Output

Learners should identify that the message is missing:

Missing Element	Example
Context	Which report? Which data?
Specific question	What exactly is confusing?
Urgency	When is help needed?
Next step	What will the intern do after receiving clarification?

Assessment Check

Learners can explain why a manager may need more context and a more specific ask.

Module 2: The CLEAR Framework

Item	Details
Time	20 minutes
Learning Objective	Apply a simple structure for emails, chats, and verbal updates
Purpose	Give interns a repeatable communication structure
Materials	Slides, worksheet, CLEAR checklist

CLEAR Framework

Letter	Meaning	Explanation
C	Context	What is the situation?
L	Lead with the point	What is the main message or request?
E	Explain briefly	What does the manager need to know?
A	Ask or action	What do you need, or what will you do next?
R	Recap next step	Confirm deadline, owner, or follow-up

Facilitator Mini-Demo

Use the weak message from Module 1:

“Hi, I’m confused about the data. Can you help?”

Then model a CLEAR version:

Hi Alex, I’m working on the safety reporting draft due Thursday. I have one question about which data source to use for the incident-rate section. I found the monthly dashboard and the year-to-date export, but they show slightly different totals. Could you confirm which source I should use? Once confirmed, I can complete the draft by Thursday afternoon.

Facilitator Explanation

Point out how the improved message includes:

CLEAR Element	Where It Appears
Context	“Safety reporting draft due Thursday”
Lead with the point	“I have one question...”
Explain briefly	“I found two sources...”
Ask or action	“Could you confirm...”
Recap next step	“Once confirmed, I can complete...”

Activity: Build a CLEAR Update

Give learners this situation:

Your manager asked you to review a vendor proposal. You have completed the review, but you found two pricing items that may need clarification before the team meeting tomorrow.

Learner Task

Individually first, then in pairs, learners write a CLEAR update to their manager.

They should complete this structure in the worksheet:

CLEAR Element	Learner Response
Context	
Lead with the point	
Explain briefly	
Ask or action	
Recap next step	

Learner Actions

1. Write individually for 3 minutes.
2. Compare with a partner for 4 minutes.
3. Improve the message together.
4. Share one example with the group.

Facilitator Debrief Questions

Ask:

1. What changed when you added context?
2. What made the message easier for a manager to act on?
3. What details were useful, and what details were unnecessary?

Assessment Check

Learners can produce a communication message that includes the five CLEAR elements.

Module 3: Message Makeover Challenge

Item	Details
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Time	20 minutes
Learning Objective	Differentiate casual, professional, and leadership-facing communication styles
Purpose	Help interns improve tone, clarity, and professionalism in email and chat
Materials	Slides, worksheet, scenario cards

Key Concept

Professional communication does not mean sounding cold or robotic.

Professional communication means being:

Quality	Meaning
Respectful	Appropriate tone for the audience
Clear	Easy to understand
Useful	Helps the reader take action
Concise	Avoids unnecessary detail
Confident	Shows ownership without sounding demanding

Activity: Message Makeover Challenge

Divide learners into small groups. Give each group one weak message and ask them to rewrite it for a senior manager or project lead.

Weak Message Examples

Message 1: Too casual

Hey, just wondering if you saw my thing from yesterday lol. Need your thoughts when you can.

Message 2: Too vague

Hi, I have a question about the project. Can we talk?

Message 3: Too long

Hi Maria, I was looking at the report and then I checked the file that Sam sent, but I also saw another version in the folder, and I'm not totally sure which one is right because they look kind of similar but also different, so I was wondering if maybe you could let me know what you think when you have time.

Message 4: Too passive

Sorry to bother you, but I don't really know if this is right. Maybe I can change it if you want.

Learner Task

Each group rewrites the message using:

1. Professional tone
2. Clear context
3. Specific request
4. Appropriate next step

Optional Scorecard

Groups use this scorecard:

Criteria	Yes / Not Yet
Is the purpose clear?	
Is the tone professional?	
Is the request specific?	
Is the message concise?	
Is there a next step?	

Facilitator Actions

1. Assign each group a message.
2. Give 6 minutes for rewriting.
3. Ask groups to read the original and improved version.
4. Invite learners to vote on the strongest improvement.
5. Debrief what made the revised messages stronger.

Sample Improved Version

Original:

Hey, just wondering if you saw my thing from yesterday lol. Need your thoughts when you can.

Improved:

Hi Jordan, I'm following up on the draft summary I sent yesterday for the fleet maintenance project. Could you share your feedback by 3 p.m. today so I can make revisions before tomorrow's meeting?

Assessment Check

Learners can revise a message to improve tone, clarity, and actionability.

Module 4: Speaking Up and Asking Better Questions

Item	Details
Time	15 minutes
Learning Objective	Demonstrate how to ask specific questions and clarify expectations
Purpose	Build confidence in meetings and manager conversations
Materials	Slides, worksheet, role-play prompt

Key Concept

A strong question usually includes:

Element	Example
What you already did	"I reviewed the project brief and checked the shared folder."
What you are unsure about	"I'm unsure which template to use."
What you need	"Could you confirm whether I should use the operations template or the finance template?"
What happens next	"Once confirmed, I can complete the first draft by Friday."

Activity: Ask Better Questions Role-Play

Scenario

Your manager gives you a task during a quick meeting: “Can you put together a short update for next week’s project review?”

You are not sure what “short update” means, who the audience is, or what format your manager expects.

Learner Task

In pairs:

- Person A plays the intern.
- Person B plays the manager.
- The intern practices asking 2–3 clarifying questions.

Suggested Question Starters

Purpose	Sentence Starter
Clarify audience	“Who will be the main audience for this update?”
Clarify format	“Would you prefer a short email summary or a slide?”
Clarify scope	“Which parts of the project should I focus on?”
Clarify deadline	“When would you like to review the first draft?”
Confirm next step	“Great, I’ll prepare a one-page summary by Wednesday.”

Facilitator Actions

1. Explain the role-play.
2. Give pairs 5 minutes to practice.
3. Ask pairs to switch roles if time allows.
4. Invite volunteers to share one strong question.
5. Debrief the value of clarifying early.

Facilitator Debrief

Key message:

Asking questions does not make you look unprepared. A clear, specific question shows that you are thinking ahead and trying to deliver the right result.

Assessment Check

Learners can ask a specific question that includes context, clarification, and next step.

Module 5: Feedback and Follow-Up

Item	Details
Time	5 minutes
Learning Objective	Respond to feedback using a professional and growth-oriented approach
Purpose	Help interns respond calmly and constructively to manager feedback
Materials	Slides, worksheet

Key Concept

A professional feedback response includes:

Step	Example
Acknowledge	“Thank you for the feedback.”
Clarify	“Could you confirm which section needs the most revision?”
Act	“I’ll update it and send the revised version by Friday.”
Learn	“I’ll use this structure for future reports.”

Activity: Choose the Best Response

Show this scenario:

Your manager says: “This update has useful information, but it is too detailed for the leadership meeting. Please make it shorter and focus on the key decision points.”

Ask learners:

Which response is strongest?

- A. “Oh, sorry. I didn’t know. I’ll fix it.”
- B. “I included the details because I thought they were important.”
- C. “Thank you. I’ll revise it to focus on the key decision points. Could you confirm if you want it limited to one page?”
- D. “Okay.”

Correct Answer

C is strongest because it acknowledges the feedback, confirms the improvement needed, and asks a useful clarification question.

Assessment Check

Learners can select and explain a professional response to feedback.

Closing: 30-Day Communication Commitment

Item	Details
Time	5 minutes
Learning Objective	Create a personal 30-day communication action plan
Purpose	Support transfer from training to workplace
Materials	Worksheet, CLEAR checklist

Learner Task

Learners complete the final section of the worksheet:

In the next 30 days, I will improve my communication by:

Prompt	Learner Response
One communication habit I want to improve	
One situation where I will use CLEAR	
One question I will ask my manager to clarify expectations	
One action I will take after receiving feedback	

Facilitator Closing Message

Communication is a workplace skill that improves with practice. You do not need to have perfect wording every time. What matters is that you communicate with clarity, respect, and ownership.

Assessment Check

Learners leave with one specific communication action they can apply during the internship.

5. Facilitator Notes

Tone of Facilitation

The facilitator should keep the session:

Tone	Meaning
Supportive	Do not shame interns for communication mistakes
Practical	Use examples instead of theory-heavy explanations
Energetic	Keep transitions quick and activities moving
Inclusive	Allow participation through writing, chat, pairs, or group discussion
Professional	Avoid making the session feel childish or overly gamified

Key Messages to Reinforce

Message	Why It Matters
Communication expectations vary by role and context	Avoids generational stereotyping
Professional does not mean robotic	Helps interns sound natural but polished
Clear questions show preparation	Reduces fear of asking for help
Concise updates help managers act faster	Connects communication to business value
Feedback is part of learning	Builds resilience and growth mindset
Confidence comes from structure and practice	Makes improvement feel achievable

6. Participation Strategy

To maintain higher participation, the lesson uses a learner action every 7–10 minutes.

Time	Learner Participation
0–10 min	Poll and discussion
10–25 min	Manager Lens scenario

25–45 min	CLEAR message practice
45–65 min	Message Makeover Challenge
65–80 min	Ask Better Questions role-play
80–85 min	Feedback response activity
85–90 min	30-day action plan

This keeps the session active and prevents it from becoming a passive lecture.

7. Assessment Summary

Learning Objective	Assessment Method
Identify manager expectations	Manager Lens discussion
Differentiate tone levels	Message Makeover Challenge
Apply CLEAR framework	CLEAR update practice
Ask specific questions	Pair role-play
Respond to feedback	Best-response activity
Create action plan	30-day commitment

8. Post-Training Reinforcement

After the session, learners should receive:

Reinforcement Tool	Purpose
CLEAR checklist	Helps interns structure future communication
Completed worksheet	Reminds learners of their own practice examples
30-day action plan	Encourages transfer
Manager check-in prompt	Helps managers reinforce communication expectations

Suggested Manager Check-In Prompt

Managers can ask interns after 30 days:

What communication habit have you been practicing since onboarding, and where would you like more feedback?